

Carcharhinus melanopterus

Blacktip reef shark

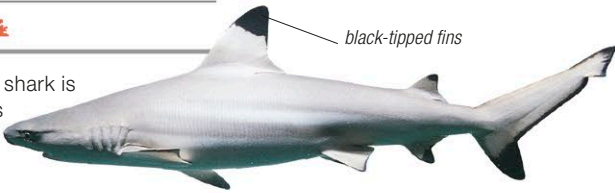


Length Up to 6½ ft (2 m)
Weight Over 99 lb (45 kg)
Breeding Viviparous
Status Near threatened

Location Tropical Indo-Pacific



The blacktip reef shark is a familiar species of shark in the tropical



Indo-Pacific region. This shark usually occurs in shallow water, and the dorsal and upper tail fin may project above the surface of the water. People wading and swimming are frequently bitten, but though curious of divers, it is more circumspect with them. The blacktip reef shark has a streamlined body, which makes it an active and powerful swimmer. As its name suggests, the tips of the fins are black.

Negaprion brevirostris

Lemon shark



Length Up to 11 ft (3.4 m)
Weight Over 410 lb (185 kg)
Breeding Viviparous
Status Near threatened

Location E. Pacific, W. and E. Atlantic



The lemon, or sharptooth, shark adapts well to captivity and hence is one of the most-studied members of the requiem shark family. Normally unaggressive, it is

capable of a powerful bite and may attack humans if provoked. Yellowish to light brown in color, this fish has large fins and an abrupt snout. The lemon shark is adapted to survive in brackish waters and areas of low oxygen. It feeds mainly on bony fishes, guitarfishes, and stingrays, but may also eat crustaceans and molluscs. Adults are most active at night; the juveniles by day.



Prionace glauca

Blue shark

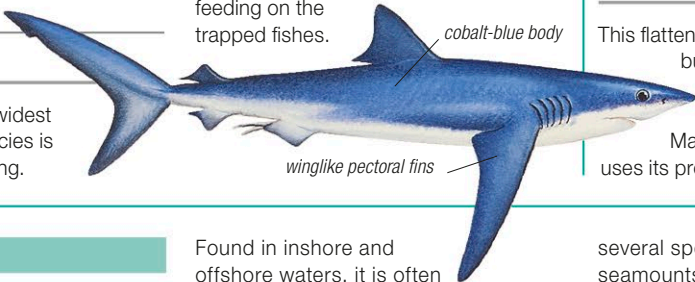


Length 12 ft (3.8 m) or more
Weight Over 440 lb (200 kg)
Breeding Viviparous
Status Near threatened

Location Tropical and temperate waters worldwide



Although possibly the widest ranging shark, this species is threatened by overfishing.



It migrates seasonally following complex inshore and transoceanic routes. Blue sharks are usually wary of divers but have been known to attack humans. They sometimes circle potential prey before attacking, and large numbers may gather around a whale or porpoise carcass in a feeding frenzy, biting at chunks of floating debris. They may also be seen following trawlers, and feeding on the trapped fishes.

Triaenodon obesus

Whitetip reef shark

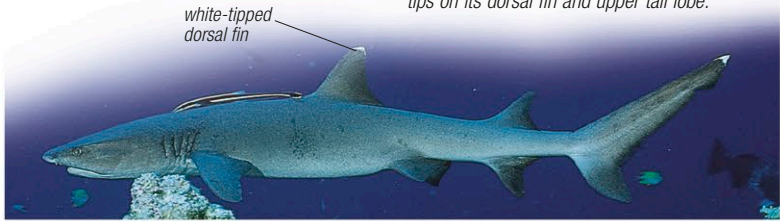


Length 5¼ ft (1.6 m), max 7 ft (2.1 m)
Weight Over 40 lb (18 kg)
Breeding Viviparous
Status Near threatened

Location Tropical Indo-Pacific



While most sharks must swim continuously, mouth agape, to force oxygenated water across their gills, the whitetip reef shark, or blunthead, can pump water across its gills and can therefore rest on the ocean floor. It relies heavily on sound and smell for catching prey—often associating the sound of boat engines with the opportunity to steal fishes, it doggedly pursues speared fishes and may bite fishermen. Nevertheless, it is generally nonaggressive.



WHITE MARKERS
This slender shark has distinctive white tips on its dorsal fin and upper tail lobe.

Squatina dumeril

Sand devil



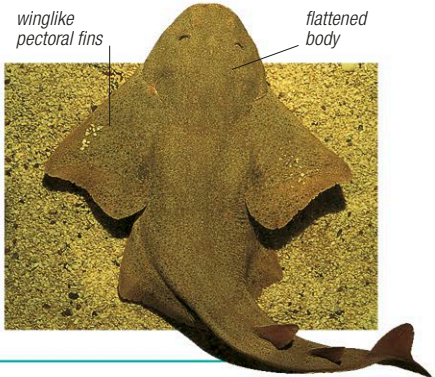
Length Up to 5 ft (1.5 m)
Weight Over 60 lb (27 kg)
Breeding Viviparous
Status Data deficient

Location W. North Atlantic



This flattened fish is often found partially buried in sand on the sea floor, its nondescript coloration serving as camouflage. Mainly a sit-and-wait predator, it uses its protrusible mouth to strike with

lightning speed at unwary prey, consisting chiefly of crustaceans and other fishes. One of about 14 similar species, the sand devil (or angelshark) is commercially fished for its flesh, skin, and oil.



Sphyrna zygaena

Smooth hammerhead



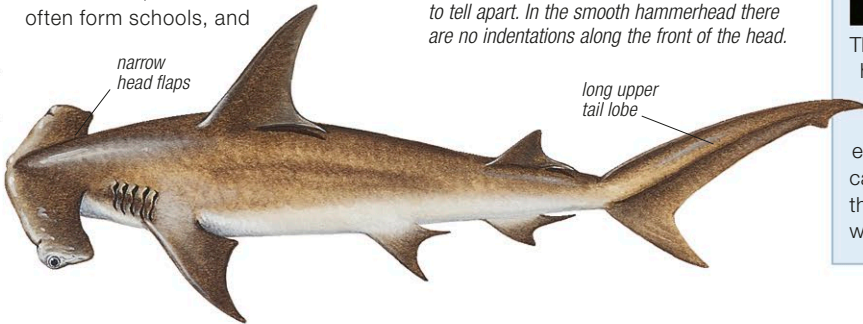
Length Up to 13 ft (4 m)
Weight Up to 880 lb (400 kg)
Breeding Viviparous
Status Vulnerable

Location Tropical, subtropical, and temperate waters worldwide



The smooth hammerhead is one of 8 species of hammerhead sharks, instantly identifiable by their bizarre heads, which have eyes at the end of winglike extensions, or “hammers”.

Found in inshore and offshore waters, it is often seen at the surface, with its large dorsal fin slicing through the water. Like all hammerheads, it is generally shy but is potentially dangerous. It feeds on a wide variety of fishes, including other sharks. Unlike most other sharks, hammerheads often form schools, and



several species do so around seamounts. These aggregations may be for feeding or breeding. As hammerheads are top predators, it is highly unlikely that these groups form for protection from other predators.

IDENTIFYING FEATURES
Species of hammerhead sharks can be difficult to tell apart. In the smooth hammerhead there are no indentations along the front of the head.

UNIQUE ANATOMY



The hammerheads' strange head anatomy provides several advantages, including all-round vision, and space for more electrical receptors with which it can track prey. Some species use the “hammer” to pin down stingrays while they feed on them.